

Women's Specialists of Clear Lake

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Rh Negative Blood Type in Pregnancy

Understanding Rh sensitization and how RhoGAM protects your baby

WHAT IS RH FACTOR?

The Rh factor is a protein on the surface of red blood cells. If you have it, you are Rh-positive (+). If not, you are Rh-negative (–). About **15% of people** are Rh-negative. If you are Rh– and your baby is Rh+ (from the father), your immune system may see the baby's blood cells as "foreign" and make antibodies against them.

WHY DOES IT MATTER?

- In a *first* pregnancy, sensitization rarely causes problems
- In subsequent Rh+ pregnancies, antibodies cross the placenta and attack baby's red blood cells
- This causes **hemolytic disease of the newborn (HDN)** — anemia, jaundice, heart failure
- Risk increases with each untreated sensitizing event
- Prevention with RhoGAM is highly effective

RHOGAM INJECTION SCHEDULE

- 1 **28 weeks** — routine prenatal RhoGAM injection if unsensitized
- 2 **After delivery** — within 72 hours, if baby is Rh+
- 3 **After miscarriage** — regardless of gestational age
- 4 **After amniocentesis or CVS**
- 5 **After trauma/bleeding** — any event that may mix blood
- 6 **After external cephalic version (ECV)**

WHAT IS RHOGAM?

- RhoGAM is Rh immune globulin (anti-D) **RX**
- Given as an IM injection (arm or buttock)
- Works by "mopping up" any Rh+ fetal cells in your bloodstream before your immune system can respond
- Does NOT protect you if you are already sensitized
- Safe during pregnancy — does not harm the baby
- Protection lasts approximately 12 weeks

SENSITIZING EVENTS REQUIRING RHOGAM

- Vaginal bleeding during pregnancy
- Miscarriage, ectopic pregnancy, or termination
- Amniocentesis or chorionic villus sampling (CVS)
- Abdominal trauma (fall, car accident)
- External cephalic version (baby turning)
- Manual placenta removal
- Placental abruption

IF ALREADY SENSITIZED

- Titer testing to measure antibody levels
- Serial Doppler ultrasounds of baby's brain blood flow (MCA-PSV)
- If fetal anemia detected, intrauterine blood transfusion possible
- Close monitoring by maternal-fetal medicine specialist
- Neonatology team present at delivery
- RhoGAM will NOT help once sensitized

⚠️ CALL YOUR DOCTOR IF YOU ARE RH– AND EXPERIENCE

- ⚠️ Any vaginal bleeding at any point in pregnancy
- ⚠️ Signs of miscarriage (cramping + bleeding)
- ⚠️ More than 72 hours have passed since delivery of Rh+ baby
- ⚠️ New pregnancy — inform your doctor of Rh status early
- ⚠️ Abdominal trauma or a car accident
- ⚠️ You missed your 28-week RhoGAM injection
- ⚠️ Decreased fetal movement after sensitizing event
- ⚠️ Any invasive prenatal procedure not yet followed by RhoGAM

♥️ RhoGAM Has Virtually Eliminated Rh Disease

Before RhoGAM was introduced in 1968, Rh incompatibility was a leading cause of newborn death and disability. Today, with timely injections, the risk of sensitization is less than 1%. This is one of modern medicine's great success stories — and your diligence in receiving your RhoGAM shots is all that is needed to protect your baby.